



Cornered in KABUL

The latest attack on Indians and Indian interests forces a re-evaluation of New Delhi's Afghanistan strategy

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Amongst the many well-kept secrets in the Foreign Office in South Block is an all-weather telephone connection through a Government exchange that connects directly to India's diplomatic mission in Kabul. These days it brings mostly bad news, as it did on February 26, with another major suicide attack in Kabul targeting Indians and Indian interests in a hotel close to the Indian mission which was used by the Indian Embassy as a transit accommodation for its staffers. The terrorist strike killed 10 Indians, including army Major Dr Laishram Jyotin Singh, Major Deepak Yadav, engineer Bhola Ram, tabla player Nawab Khan, staffer of the Kandahar Consulate Nitish Chibber and Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) constable Roshan Lal. The suicide bombers targeted guesthouses, particularly the Park Residence, rented out by the Indian Embassy for its staffers and those linked to India's development work in Afghanistan. The attack follows the one last October which killed 17 people and the most serious one in July, 2008, which left 60 dead, including senior Indian diplomats. "Last

THE BLAST SITE IN KABUL

COUNTER STRATEGY

- Indians have been advised to move in groups, alter their timings and take different routes to work.
- Send additional security personnel from the ITBP to Afghanistan to protect Indians and Indian projects.
- Plans to move Indian transit personnel in Kabul to a more secure location.
- Initiate a training programme for Afghan army personnel, including the supply of tanks and field guns.



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